

SURESH GOPI, *BJP*

CB PRADEEP KUMAR

TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 20

	UDF*	LDF	NDA
2024	18 (43.8%)	1 (33.4%)	1 (19.4%)
2019	19 (47.5%)	1 (36.3%)	0 (14.9%)

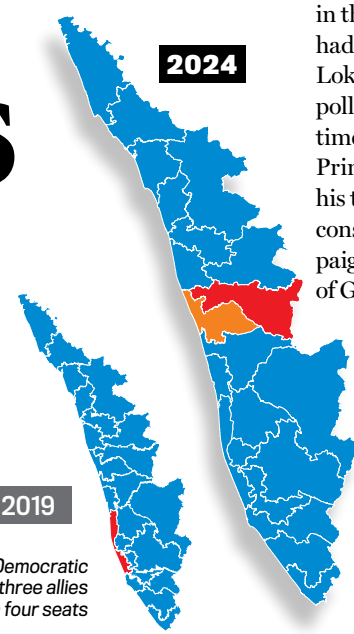
Vote share in ( )

| KERALA |

THE LOTUS BLOOMS

Despite another RaGa wave, the Kerala story takes a new turn as the BJP finally plants its flag here

By **Jeemon Jacob**



**The United Democratic Front includes three allies who won in four seats*

The last redoubt has fallen, the saffron charge has finally breached the Kerala fortress. The BJP has opened its Lok Sabha account in Thrissur, and it took an ageing Mollywood superstar to do it. Suresh Gopi, 65, the hero of umpteen action thrillers, hit the political box office jackpot in his fourth attempt here (assembly and Lok Sabha), winning by 74,686 votes against two formidable rivals, V.S. Sunilkumar of the Communist Party of India (CPI) and ex-Congress MP K. Muraleedharan, son of the late chief minister, K. Karunakaran.

It was the split in party votes that did in the Congress in their central Kerala bastion. Gopi, talking to INDIA TODAY, sounded overwhelmed, but not so much that he forgot to thank the twin poles that took him to victory. "I thank Lord Krishna...and the Mother of Lourdes for my victory. Nothing more to say," he said. The consensus is that the upper caste Hindu vote and a section of the Christian community helped Gopi breast the tape (cathedral of Our Lady of Lourdes is the big Syro-Malabar church in Thrissur).

Questions will be asked in the Congress on how they lost Thrissur in the midst of a wave in favour of the party-led United Democratic Front (the alliance won 18 out of the 20 Lok Sabha seats in the state). Gopi has been looking to "take Thrissur" since 2016, when he was first fielded in the assembly election here. He had tested his luck again in the 2019 Lok Sabha and the 2021 assembly polls, but with the same result. This time, too, he had the full backing of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his team (in fact, the PM visited the constituency thrice during the campaign; he even attended the wedding of Gopi's daughter at the Guruvayoor temple in late January).

Gopi's win is not the only happy news for the BJP. Industrialist and ex-Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar lost in a close race to three-time Thiruvananthapuram MP Shashi Tharoor in the capital, and it's only the coastal belt votes that came into play at the fag end of counting that saved the latter. The party's fast growing vote share (up to 16.7 per cent) and the spirited fight in at least two other LS seats should give heart to the cadre.

So even as the Congress celebrates another "RaGa wave" in Kerala (Rahul Gandhi won by a massive 364,422 votes in Wayanad), they and the Communists will be worried. The Left Front's dismal outing again (just one seat: Alathur) will be cause for some heartburn for the Pinarayi Vijayan government in the state. ■